Q+A

THE DANCE OF LIFE

Dancer Aditi Mangaldas's production 'WITHIN', inspired by the Nirbhaya incident, returns to the stage with a performance at Kamani Auditorium, Delhi, on April 24



Q. What is the guiding principle of your dance practice?

For me, dance must breathe the air of 'the now'. Dance with abandon, passion and humility; be immersed in it and let it be immersed in you.... Let your senses be open to the world; to every form of inspiration. But as you step onto the stage, be ready to completely empty out and let the moment be your only companion.

Q. What is the concept behind your production 'WITHIN'?

We were exploring various forms of 'relationships' for a new work, when the horrendous Nirbhaya incident happened. 'WITHIN' became an exploration of the half embrace between brutality and humanity, masculinity and femininity, the good and bad within us. It implores the audience to look within, discover this half embrace of the binaries within us.

Q. Your work can be categorised under two streams—classical Kathak and contemporary dance based on Kathak...

Kathak to me is like a dark night sky, laden with thunder clouds, carrying secret wonders. Plant a Kathak seed and water it with the extended Kathak sensibility, a Kathak tree will grow. When watered with contemporary sensibilities, a different tree, though rooted in classical Kathak, will emerge.

Q. What are you working on next?

My next work, 'Weeping RED!' is an attempt to bring into focus the trauma and suffering of children in conflict zones around the globe. It'll be a full-length production, presented in collaboration with the National Centre for Performing Arts, Mumbai, and the Symphony Orchestra of India. It will premiere in November 2026.

—with Neha Kirpal

Photograph by ARUN KUMAR